

technical sessions. It regularly conducts training programs to teach students about free software-related technologies. TCENet is the FOSS-based ERP package developed in-house to automate the day-to-day activities of the institution [tccnet.tce.edu].

In addition, there are many on-going interdisciplinary research programmes in FOSS. GLUGOT has been organising a Software Freedom Day (FStival) since 2004 to educate college and school students and the general public, in and around Madurai. This year, FStival is scheduled to be on September 12, 2009, where demo stalls and technology sessions on various FOSS tools will be conducted [fstival.tce.edu].

This group also facilitates the meeting of GLUG-Madurai at the TCE Campus. The GLUGOT members have developed software projects like TuxEdo—a distributed chess engine, Instant Messenger Jammer, and GetEz, which is an interface to the wget tool for GNOME. These projects are available on the Web as free downloads. FOSSConf09 is the first National Level Conference organised by this group.

FOSSConf'09 spread awareness about free software among new users and contributors. It was an opportunity for students of various age groups and domains, professionals (from both IT and non-IT fields) and the curious, to get introduced to FOSS, interact with each other and share their knowledge. The conference also showcased projects, research presentations on FOSS and FOSS-based contests emphasising the importance of free software technologies. There was Wi-Fi blanketing the venue, and high-speed connectivity was available to all participants at the event. In fact,

people were encouraged to bring their laptops, or Wi-Fi-enabled devices to better experience FOSSConf'09.

Over 10 different organisations hosted several projects developed in FOSS. The project stalls hosted a number of technical projects. These included TCENet (ERP for educational institutions), TAMS (a biometric and RFID-based attendance monitoring system), TOSS (a customised distro), TCE High Performance clusters, NLP Tools, Snort, an IDS, an automated Internet bandwidth controller for Linux, an SMS travel guide, a virtual music generator, a portable music player, Wimax implementation using estimation algorithms, performance analysis on Web traffic, an online vehicle insurance payment application and so on.

There were 20 demos covering the basics of Free/Open source software, educational tools, Linux thin clients, a mobile terminal, Django, SOLR Enterprise Search Server, Drupal, security power tools in Linux, auto installation of the Globus tool kit, Yavarkumana Menporutkal in Tamil, Linux commands, Office tools, live CDs, GCC, the GIMP, bioinformatics, Wireshark and other packet sniffers, GNOME, KDE, virtualisation using Sun xVM VirtualBox, etc.

In addition to the project and demo stalls, various talks were arranged in three parallel tracks. These focused on the nuts and bolts of how people can participate in the community. According to the speakers, there are plenty of reasons to be a part of the process. Helping a free software project can be a way to learn skills, explore ideas and their implementation, have fun, create employment opportunities, and work for the



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